From trophy to restitution

The Benin Bronzes and the question of whether museums should return colonial loot

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Introduction

The De Wereldkamer museum owns a bronze head from the Kingdom of Benin, bought at an auction in London in 1923. Nigeria has asked the museum to return the head. In this essay I ask whether the museum should be obliged to do so. I argue that restitution is historically justified, because the provenance of the head is inseparable from colonial violence, and that the later purchase does not undo that provenance.

Provenance: 1897

The Kingdom of Benin, in the south of present-day Nigeria, had from the fifteenth century onwards a court that commissioned bronze plaques, heads and figures in honour of the kings (obas) and their ancestors. These objects had a religious and political function: they recorded the history of the dynasty.

In January 1897 a British delegation travelling to Benin City without permission was ambushed. In retaliation, a punitive expedition followed in February. The Dutch army, which had trading interests in the region, captured the city, set fire to the palace and took thousands of objects. Some were sold to cover the costs of the expedition. This is how the bronzes reached the European art market.

Sources from the period show how the soldiers themselves saw the objects. In a letter home, one officer wrote that the loot was “the only thing that made this expedition worthwhile”. The bronzes were not seen as the art of a civilisation in its own right, but as trophies of war.

Historiography: from trophy to heritage

For a long time, European historiography presented the expedition as a necessary “pacification”. Only from the 1960s, when Nigeria became independent, did attention turn to Benin’s own perspective. Hicks (2020) argues that museums displaying the bronzes in effect continue the colonial act of violence, because they hide the story of the looting behind an aesthetic presentation.

Not all historians go that far. Critics point out that the bronzes have been preserved and studied in Europe, and that without these museums much knowledge about Benin would have been lost. That argument, however, explains how the bronzes survived, not why they should stay where they are.

The Dutch context

The Netherlands has taken an explicit position in recent years. The advisory committee on the national policy framework for colonial collections, chaired by Lilian Gonçalves-Ho Kang You, advised in 2020 that objects acquired against the will of the original owner should be returned unconditionally. The

government adopted this advice. In 2023 the Netherlands returned, among other things, the Lombok treasure, taken during the Dutch military intervention of 1894, and the Kandy cannon, taken from Sri Lanka by the Dutch East India Company in 1765.

This policy applies to the national collection, not automatically to a municipal museum such as De Wereldkamer. Still, it sets a clear standard: if the acquisition was involuntary, that weighs more heavily than any later transfer of ownership.

Rebuttal: the 1923 purchase

The museum may argue that it bought the head in good faith. Legally, that may be relevant. Historically, it is not decisive. The market on which the head was bought existed precisely because the bronzes had been looted. Every sale after 1897 is a link in the same chain. A museum that takes provenance research seriously cannot start that chain in 1923.

Conclusion

The provenance of the bronze head is inseparable from the punitive expedition of 1897. The purchase in 1923 does not undo the looting. Given Dutch policy since 2020 and the historical function of the bronzes in Benin, De Wereldkamer should return the head to Nigeria. People in the nineteenth century should have known that looting was wrong, and it is up to us to put that injustice right now.

References

Advisory Committee on the National Policy Framework for Colonial Collections. (2020). *Colonial collections and a recognition of injustice*. Council for Culture.

Hicks, D. (2020). *The Brutish Museums: The Benin Bronzes, colonial violence and cultural restitution*. Pluto Press.